representation of relationships. The real emotional power lies in memory, flashbacks to those winning dressing rooms, celebrating with my mates.

That idea, of satisfaction gained through the knowledge you have given everything to the group, offers a clue to why we do what we do. An appreciation of playing your part, understanding what the achievement means to others, creates an amazing high. Some might see the 2010–11 Ashes tour as a personal statement, enshrined in the record books, but it wasn't undertaken alone.

International sport stimulates the senses, not least your hearing. Two contrasting moments, against Australia at home and away, are a private soundtrack, playing in my head. The first explains why one of the items on my post-retirement bucket list was to spend the first day of the Lord's Test watching from the Long Room.

I knew I wouldn't be able to recreate the tension and pressure of personal expectation but wanted to be able to experience it from an alternative angle. You never lose the sense of privilege, playing there, but when there is a job to be done you have tunnel vision. You simply don't notice the portraits and the chandeliered splendour.

Walking out to bat at HQ carries the same mystique for a cricketer as driving off at St Andrews has for a golfer. You're surrounded by ghosts, touched by history. The difference is that players do not access the first tee from the R&A clubhouse. No walk to the wicket has greater resonance than that which takes you right, out of the first-floor dressing room, down two flights of the mahogany staircase, left through the Long Room, then right through the double doors and into the daylight.

I still get goose bumps when I close my eyes and recall that experience in the first innings, against Australia in 2009. The noise the MCC members made, packed together in the Long Room like a strangely colourful army awaiting inspection, was extraordinary. It was the sound of posh people cheering. You may laugh, but that's the only way I can describe it.

There's a moment's peace as you walk to the middle with your mate. On that morning, Andrew Strauss and I looked at each other, awestruck. 'What was that?' he asked, aghast. 'Jesus, that was special, wasn't it?' To be honest, I felt like babbling, but knew we had to recalibrate. 'Yeah,' I agreed. 'How good was that? Come on. It'll mean nothing if we don't score runs.'

Those are often moments of truth. Michael Atherton tells a similar story, of walking out with Mark Lathwell for his second, and final, Test